

FREE PORT GUIDE · PORT OF CALL

Puerto Plata, Dominican Republic
Your Margaritaville at Sea day ashore

Green mountains, waterfalls, a Victorian old town and real Dominican flavor on the DR's Amber Coast.

SHIPS THAT CALL HERE
Beachcomber on many sailings, plus select Paradise sailings (2027 and later)

GETTING TO TOWN
Taíno Bay: walk or a short taxi ride. Amber Cove: about 20–25 minutes by taxi

ISLAND TIME
Atlantic time, no daylight saving. Always go by ship time

TWO CRUISE PORTS
Taíno Bay (in the city) or Amber Cove (about 10 miles west). Your daily Cruise News says which

MONEY
Dominican peso; U.S. dollars are widely accepted in tourist areas

ID AND LANGUAGE
Bring your passport. Spanish is spoken, with English in tourist spots

🛳️ Stepping off the ship

At Taíno Bay

- At the **edge of the historic center**, with a free pool, shops and bars inside the gates. Walk into the old town or take a **registered taxi**.

At Amber Cove

- A resort-style port with bars, shops and a pool. **Don't walk out to town**; there's no safe footpath, so take a taxi or tour.

Getting around

- Use the **official port taxis** and **agree on the price before you get in**. Many have posted flat rates to popular spots. Prices are per car.
- Pay cash (small U.S. bills or pesos), and ask if the fare is round trip.
- For waterfalls and the mountain, a **booked tour** is the easiest and safest way to go.

⏰ **The golden rule:** be back at the pier **at least an hour before all-aboard**. Traffic in the city can be slow, and the ship will not wait.

🌴 Pick your perfect Puerto Plata day

🚡 Cable car up Mount Isabel de Torres

Short taxi ride from Taíno Bay

Ride the cable car to the mountaintop, where a botanical garden, a Christ statue and huge views over the city and coast wait. Go early, before clouds roll in.

💦 Damajagua waterfalls

Half day by tour

Climb, swim, slide and jump down a series of natural limestone waterfalls with a guide. Life jackets and helmets are provided. Wear water shoes and clothes you don't mind getting soaked. It's an unforgettable day.

🏰 Old town and Umbrella Street

Walk from Taíno Bay

Wander the Victorian-era center, snap photos under the colorful umbrellas, visit the 16th-century Fortaleza San Felipe on the waterfront, and stop by the Amber Museum to see ancient insects trapped in stone.

🏖️ Beach day

About 10–30 min by taxi

Nearby beaches like Cosita Rica and Costambar are close to town, and Playa Dorada and the lively town of Sosúa are a bit farther. Swimming isn't allowed at the beach beside the cruise pier.

🍫 Rum, cacao and cigars

Half day by tour

Tours visit local cacao farms and chocolate makers, a rum distillery and hand-rolled cigar shops. It's a tasty way to learn about Dominican culture.

🏊 Stay at the port

Zero travel time

Both ports have pools, bars and shops, and Taíno Bay even has a lazy river and a zip line. It's perfect for a relaxed day with no worries about getting back.

🍽️ Local flavors to try

- **La bandera:** the classic Dominican plate of rice, beans and stewed meat.
- **Tostones:** crispy twice-fried green plantains.
- **Mangú:** mashed plantains, a beloved local comfort food.
- **A cold Presidente** beer or a Dominican rum drink. 🍹
- **Dominican coffee and chocolate** to take home.
- **Drink bottled water only,** not tap water.

💵 Money, shopping and tipping

- **Bring small U.S. bills.** Prices are often shown in both dollars and pesos, and change may come back in pesos.
- Cards work at bigger shops and restaurants. Taxis and vendors want cash.
- Local treasures: **amber** and **larimar**, a blue stone found only in the DR. Buy from reputable shops.
- Tip about 10% at restaurants (a service charge is often included), and tip your guides.

☀️ Weather and staying safe

Puerto Plata is warm and green all year, with highs in the 80s °F. Expect quick tropical showers, especially from May to November, and hurricane season runs June through November.

👉 **Check the forecast before you go:** **Puerto Plata 10-day forecast on weather.com** (or scan the code).

Health and comfort

- Drink **bottled water**, and skip ice from street stands.
- Bring bug spray for the mountain and waterfalls.
- Sunscreen, a hat and water shoes are must-haves for outdoor tours.

Smart cruiser habits

- Stick to **registered taxis and reputable tours**, and confirm prices up front.
- Keep phones and jewelry out of sight in busy areas, and leave valuables on board.
- Politely say "no, gracias" to persistent street sellers.
- Bring your passport ashore, or a copy if your ship advises keeping it on board.

🎒 Your Puerto Plata day bag

- [ ] Ship card (room key) and passport
- [ ] Small U.S. bills for taxis and tips
- [ ] Sunscreen, hat and sunglasses
- [ ] Bug spray
- [ ] Swimsuit and water shoes for waterfalls
- [ ] Bottled water
- [ ] Phone set to **ship time**, with an alarm
- [ ] Ship's port agent number from your Cruise News
- [ ] Waterproof phone pouch
- [ ] A light rain jacket or poncho

Want the best of Puerto Plata without the guesswork?

Our travel advisors can line up waterfall adventures, cable car rides, beach days and culture tours that fit your ship's time in port.

📲 **Scan the code** to browse and book Puerto Plata shore excursions.

Questions? **admin@thechillcompass.com**

Information current as of October 2026, gathered from port information, tourism and cruise travel sources. Piers, times, prices and fares change, so please confirm with your ship's daily Cruise News before heading out. Travel times are approximate. Excursions are booked through Shore Excursions Group, and we may earn a commission at no extra cost to you. The Chill Compass is an independent blog and is not affiliated with, endorsed by or sponsored by Margaritaville at Sea or Margaritaville Enterprises. All trademarks belong to their respective owners. Presented by Cruises Tours and Travel, LLC · Florida Seller of Travel Reg. No. ST150140.